

Usability Report

LIS 636 - Website Production and Usability for Librarians

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I. Executive Summary

This usability report reviews the Cumberland County Public Library website. The purpose of this study was to see how well users could complete common tasks on the site, such as finding library card information, children's resources, and library locations or hours.

The study used distance think-aloud testing and card sorting with three adult participants. Overall, the website has a lot of helpful information, but some areas were not as easy to find as users expected. Finding how to get a library card was the easiest task because the button was clearly labeled. Finding library locations and hours was the most difficult task because participants expected that information to be easier to find in one place.

Based on the results, the main recommendations are to make locations and hours more visible, organize the homepage links into smaller categories, make the Kids section easier to notice, and add short descriptions for broad labels so users can better understand where each link will take them.

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III. Contextual Information About the Site

The website I chose is the Cumberland County Public Library website. The library page is part of the larger Cumberland County government website, so users see both county navigation and library-specific information.

The library homepage includes links such as Catalog / My Account, Calendar, Resources & Research, Locations, Get a Library Card, Local History, Kids, Using the Library, Reader's Corner, and Submit Feedback. These links are useful because they help users access common library services quickly. However, since the site serves many users, including parents, children, older adults, and community members, the navigation needs to be clear and easy to scan.

IV. Discussion of Testing Methods Used

For this report, I used think-aloud testing and card sorting. During the think-aloud test, participants were asked to complete three tasks while explaining what they were thinking. This helped show where users expected to click and what parts of the site felt easy or confusing.

The card sort was used to see how participants would organize common library website topics. This helped show whether the site's organization matches how users naturally group information.

V. Contextual Information on Test Participants

Participant 1 is a mother in her mid-30s with two children in elementary school. She uses the internet daily for school updates, shopping, maps, and local information.

Participant 2 is a man in his early 40s who works full time and uses the internet regularly, but he does not usually visit library websites.

Participant 3 is a woman in her late 60s who uses the internet for email, news, Facebook, and basic searches. She prefers websites that are simple and easy to follow.

VI. Think-Aloud Protocol Testing and Results

Each participant completed 3 tasks on the Cumberland County Public Library website.

Task 1: Find out how to get a library card.

Task 2: Find children's resources or programs.

Task 3: Find library locations or hours.

Task 1: Get a Library Card

This was the easiest task for participants. Participant 1 first clicked "How do I" because she expected that section to explain how to get a library card. She later found the "Get a Library Card" button and said the button was clear. Participant 2 also started with "How do I," then found "Library Card" under the "Apply for" section. Participant 3 found the "Get a Library Card" button quickly and said, "I think it's pretty obvious right?"

Overall, the "Get a Library Card" button worked well, but two participants clicked "How do I" first. This suggests that users may expect library card information to appear in more than one place.

Task 2: Find Children's Resources or Programs

All participants found children's resources, but not everyone found them right away. Participant 1 first clicked "Using the Library" before returning to the main page and finding "Kids." She said, "It looks like I seem to go on a wrong button before finding out the right one is just a scroll away."

Participant 2 clicked “Departments” and “How do I” before finding “Kids” in the side menu. Participant 3 found the Kids button more easily and said, “That wasn’t hard to find.”

This shows that the Kids section is useful, but it could be made more noticeable for parents and families.

Task 3: Find Library Locations or Hours

This was the most confusing task. Participant 1 clicked “About Us” and found contact information, but it seemed to show the Headquarters Library only. She said, “I think this is the location for the main library but where is the Hope Mills one?” Participant 2 clicked “Contact Us,” then “About Us,” then “Using the Library,” and finally “Locations.” Participant 3 clicked “Using the Library” and “Reader’s Corner” before looking for location information. She said, “The hours are usually with the phone number and address but I didn’t see that.”

Overall, participants expected locations and hours to be easier to find together. A clearer label like “Locations & Hours” would help users find this information faster.

VII. Card Sort Testing and Results

For the card sort, participants grouped library website topics into categories that made sense to them. The cards included topics such as

- Catalog / My Account
- Calendar
- Resources & Research
- Locations
- Get a Library Card
- Kids
- Using the Library
- Reader’s Corner
- Submit Feedback
- Homework Help for Kids
- Free Downloads
- Borrowing

- Fines and Fees
- Home Delivery & Accessibility
- Contact Information.

Participant 1 grouped the cards around family use and basic library needs. She placed Get a Library Card, Using the Library, Borrowing, Fines and Fees, Library Locations, and Contact Information together. She also grouped Kids, Homework Help for Kids, and Calendar together.

Participant 2 grouped the cards by task. He connected Catalog / My Account, Reader's Corner, Resources & Research, Library Resource Guides, and Free Downloads because they all related to finding materials or information. He grouped Locations, Calendar, and Contact Information together because they helped with planning a library visit.

Participant 3 preferred simple categories. She grouped Get a Library Card, Library Locations, Contact Information, and Using the Library as basic information. She grouped Kids, Homework Help for Kids, and Calendar as children's services.

Overall, the card sort showed that participants grouped items by user need. Many participants expected library basics, children's services, reading materials, and research help to be grouped separately. This suggests that the homepage links could be organized into clearer categories.

VIII. Recommendations and Future Research Needs

Recommendation 1: Change "Locations" to "Locations & Hours"

Participants had the most trouble finding branch locations and hours. A clearer label would help users understand that this section includes both location and schedule information.

Recommendation 2: Group quick links into smaller categories

The homepage quick links are useful, but there are many options. The site could group them into categories such as Library Basics, For Kids and Families, Find Books and Reading, Research Help, and Library Support.

Recommendation 3: Make the Kids section easier to notice

All participants found the Kids section, but some clicked the wrong links first. Grouping Kids, Homework Help for Kids, and children's events together would help families find information faster.

Recommendation 4: Add short descriptions under broad labels

Labels like "Resources & Research," "Using the Library," and "Reader's Corner" may not be clear to every user. Short descriptions would help users know what to expect before clicking.

Recommendation 5: Make the library section more distinct from the county website

Some participants were confused by the larger Cumberland County navigation. Making library-specific navigation more noticeable could help users stay focused on library services.

Future Research Needs

For future research, it would be helpful to test the website with a larger and more diverse group of users. This could include parents, teens, older adults, new library users, and people who mostly use the website on a phone. Testing with more users would give a better understanding of how different people use the site.

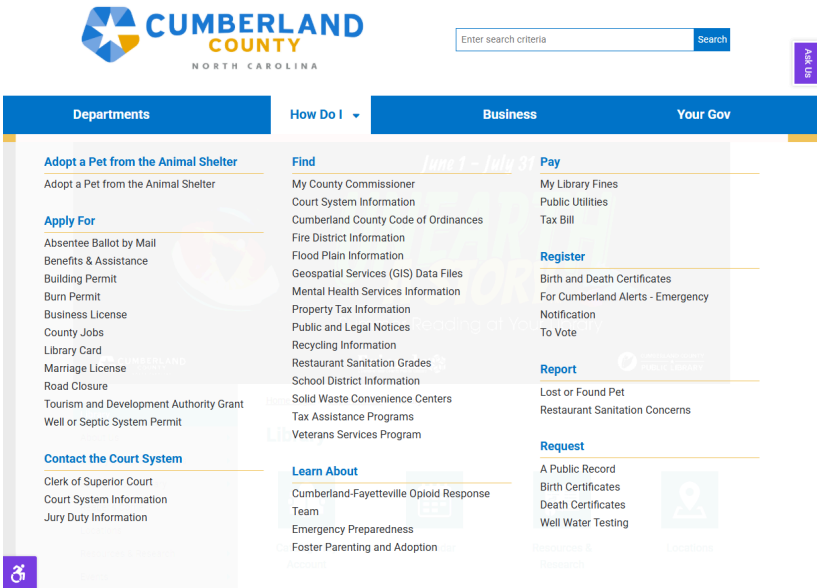
It would also be useful to focus on the pages that caused the most confusion, especially the Locations page, Kids page, and Resources & Research section. Future testing could look more closely at whether users can quickly find branch hours, children’s programs, homework help, and online resources.

IX. Illustrative Images



Figure 1. Cumberland County Public Library homepage and main quick-link section.

Figure 2. “How Do I” county navigation menu.



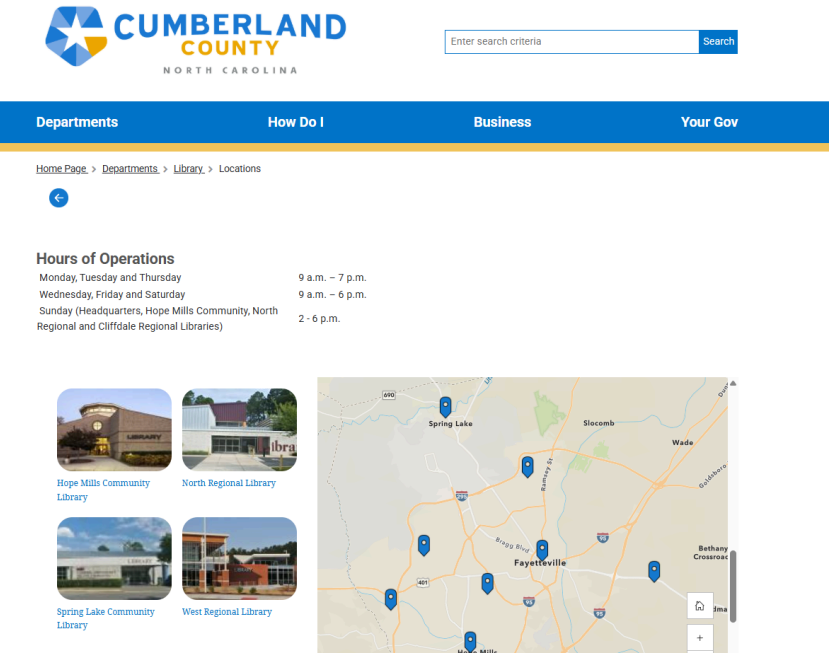


Figure 3. Library Locations and Hours page.

Figure 4. Cumberland County Public Library quick-link section

